
15th Sunday in Ordinary Time (Year A)

12 July 2026

The Soil of Our Lives

This Sunday Jesus tells us the parable of the sower. It is one of the most familiar stories in the Gospels. A farmer scatters seed. Some falls on the path, some on rocky ground, some among thorns, and some on rich soil. Only the rich soil produces a harvest.

Anyone who has ever grown anything in soil knows that you can have the best seed in the world, but if the ground isn't ready, nothing will come of it. The work is in the preparation. The digging, the clearing, the weeding. It is slow and unspectacular, and nobody sees it. But it makes all the difference.

Isaiah reminds us this weekend that God's Word never returns to Him empty. Like the rain and the snow that water the earth, His word always accomplishes what it was sent to do. The seed is never the problem. God is endlessly generous. He scatters His grace everywhere, on all of us, without measure and without favourites. The question the parable puts to each of us is a simple one: what kind of ground is He landing on?

Every one of us has been planted with gifts. Gifts of faith, of kindness, of patience, of prayer. Some of them are lying dormant because the soil of our lives has become hardened, or crowded, or shallow. The worries of the week, the busyness, the old hurts we haven't let go of — these are the thorns and the stones. They don't destroy the seed. They just stop it growing.

The good news is that soil can always be worked: A little time in prayer each day. An honest look at what is choking the Word in us. A return to the Sacraments. Small, quiet acts of clearing the ground! When we do that, our roots go down deeper into God, and we find a steadiness that the heat of life cannot wither.

St Paul tells us the whole of creation is groaning, waiting to be set free. That freedom begins in small plots of ground, that is in hearts like yours and mine that let the Word take root and grow.

So this week, ask the Lord: what needs clearing in me? Then let Him in with the spade! The harvest He promises is thirty, sixty, a hundredfold.

Fr Sean

FATIMA PILGRIMAGE

I'm in Fatima with Fr Stephen Baxter (our newly ordained) and 60 others from our Parishes and others in Fatima. Please be assured of our prayers at all our Masses, Rosaries and Processions for you all and your intentions, and I ask for yours for us as well. Thanks to Fr Michael Canny PP, Fr Patrick Lagan CC and Fr Joshy Parokkaran CC from Waterside for providing cover while I'm away.

We welcome into God's Family through the Sacrament of Baptism:

Lottie Kimberley Jowett

Remy Petroosbabakhan

May they Rest in Peace

Deaths

Gerard O'Connell, 60 Belldoo

Bernard O'Brien, 2 Mourne Park

Jackie Begley, 217 Ballycolman Estate

Jim Harley, 1 Melmount Park

Thomas Martin Roulston, 89 Carlton Drive

Anniversaries

Sr. Monica O'Kane, Mary Kate Mullen, William Robinson

Conor McCarron, Tony McAleer, Susan Logue

Vincent Gormley, Betty McColgan, Ellen Jane McCormick

John Ellis, Frances O'Connor, Tommy McGarrigle

Gerard Blake, Joe Millar, Tom Skehan

Kay McGuigan, William Devine, Jude Crotty

Frank Molloy, Maureen Devine, Eunan Herron

Tommy Finlay, Harry McCrossan, Anne McCay

Magdalene Curry, Molly McDaid, David Coyle

Deirdre Drumm Pearce, Dessie Drumm, Grace Drumm

Noel Brennan, Joe McNulty, Alice Alexander

Robert Brennan, George Fitzpatrick, Francis Moss

Margaret Quigley, Packie Duncan, Frank McElwee

Michael McDaid, Ann McShane, Patrick Early

George Early, Sarah Early, George Devenney

David McDaid, Marie Henderson

Announcements

Last week's collections amounted to: **Melmount:** £3373.00; **Sion Mills:** £1465.00. Thank you. Those who pay to the weekly collection or any special collections, including Priest's Collection by cheque are asked that all cheques should be made payable to 'Melmount Parish' or 'Sion Mills Parish' depending on the Parish. This is a banking requirement. *Parishioners can still leave their contributions in the Parish Office. If the Office is closed, please use the letterbox.*

Parish Bulletin This is the last bulletin until September.

Exposition of the Blessed Sacrament will take place in St. Mary's, Melmount tomorrow, Monday 13 July after 10.00am Mass until 6.30pm.

Vocations We pray for the men called to serve the Church as priests of our diocese, that their hearts will be the fertile soil Jesus needs to receive the seed which is His Word, and that they will spread His Word, His Good News, by their preaching and by the example of their lives.

Adoration Everyday The Blessed Sacrament can be adored in the Adoration Room, St. Theresa's, Sion Mills anytime while the church is open.

Baptism Dates Melmount

July: Sunday 19; Saturday 25; Sunday 26.

August: Saturday 8; Saturday 29.

September: Saturday 5; Sunday 13; Saturday 19.

October: Sunday 4; Saturday 10; Saturday 17; Saturday 24.

November: Sunday 8; Saturday 14; Saturday 21; Saturday 28.

Baptisms will be at 3.30pm on a Saturday and 12.45pm on a Sunday.

To book a Baptism contact the Parish Office on 71383777 during office hours.

Accord Marriage Preparation Courses (Pre-Marriage Courses) will take place in September 25/26 and November 20/21. All courses are now online for booking at www.accordni.com

Please Note: These courses are in person and not online courses.

Accord Derry will NOT be facilitating courses during October or December.

Safeguarding Notice If you have any concerns with regard to the Safeguarding of children within the church please contact Marie O'Kane, the Diocesan Designated Liaison Person (DLP) on +447596500793 or email@ dlp@derrydiocese.org. *Northern Ireland emergency services:* PSNI on 101; *Social Services:* Gateway Services, Western HSC Trust, 028 71314090 and ask for the Duty Social Worker. *Regional Emergency Social Work Services* 0800 1979 995.

The Parish Draws for July and August took place on Wednesday 8 July. The winners are as follows:

July Draw

£500: 1027 Genevieve O'Neill – *Genevieve O'Neill*
£250: 1350 Concepta McGarrigle – *Ann Donaghey*
£250: 1708 Thomas Moore – *Teresa Quigg*
£250: 1338 Marianne Patton – *Carol-ann Stewart*
£150: 1995 Tammy McNulty – *Irene Callan*
£150: 1304 Ina O'Neill – *Sheelagh McKelvey*
£150: 1719 Christine McHugh – *Teresa Quigg*
£100: 1243 Bronagh Lynch – *Declan Duffy*
£100: 1669 Declan McColgan – *Madeleine McColgan*
£100: 1702 Terrie Logue - *Genevieve O'Neill*

August Draw

£500: 1756 Vincent McCarron – *Katrina Houston*
£250: 1626 Anne Neeson – *Madeleine McColgan*
£250: 1379 Gary McNicholl – *Sheelagh McKelvey*
£250: 1862 Emma Lynch – *Elizabeth O'Hare*
£150: 1825 Susan McGuinness – *John Donohoe*
£150: 1684 Teresa Boggs – *Katrina Houston*
£150: 1380 Bridget McCrory – *Sheelagh McKelvey*
£100: 1010 Mya McNulty – *Dolores Houston*
£100: 1258 Corrine Hannigan – *Elizabeth O'Hare*
£100: 1507 Jacintha Gillespie - *Elizabeth O'Hare*



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A short reflection on today's Gospel Matthew 15:21-28

Today's Gospel contains an exchange between Jesus and a Canaanite woman in which Jesus appears to exercise racism and elitism to a degree which shocks us to the core. But is this what is really taking place! Is Jesus a victim of inherited prejudice and an unquestioning acceptance of Jewish supremacy? Or is he demonstrating effectively what happens when we fail to reach out in love to all mankind: when we fail to realise that it is God's will and the will of Jesus, His beloved Son, for us to grow in universal love and care as opposed to self-love, racism and the false notion of selected supremacy! What happens is that a child remains suffering in torment while a loving mother is forced to watch on in helpless anguish. Jesus always sees into the truth which lives in the heart. He sees into the heart of the Canaanite woman. He sees her love for her tormented child. He sees her willingness to suffer insult for the sake of her child. And he sees her unflinching faith in him as her child's only hope.

Jesus, may we grow and mature daily in universal love and care, away from 'self-love and elitism' in the knowledge that it is your will that we do so.

Prayer for Vocations to the Priesthood: That the men called to priesthood will "... have a care for justice (and) act with integrity..." as they preach the message of God's salvation for everyone, the Good News that the Church is "a house of prayer for all the peoples".

"Bishop Daly - A Man for all Seasons" 2026 Exhibition celebrates the life, influence, work and legacy of Bishop Edward Daly opened on Saturday 8th August at 11.00am. Exhibition times are 11.00am to 4.00pm in the Conference Room above the Sacristy in Saint Eugene's Cathedral, Creggan Street, Derry, BT48 9AP. The Exhibition will run until 18th August and everyone is welcome.

The National Novena to Our Lady of Knock takes place at Knock Shrine from Thursday 13th to Friday 21st August 2026. Novena ceremonies will be celebrated daily at 3.00pm and 8.00pm, with workshops and guided prayer sessions also taking place throughout the nine days. This year's theme is "Sheltered in God's Love." See the full program at www.knockshrine.ie.

The St Dymphna Mass with Anointing of the Sick will be celebrated at St Eugene's Cathedral on Tuesday 18 August at 7.30pm. This Mass is to give thanks to God for positive mental health and to pray for those who are struggling with mental health issues and those who care for them.

Prayer to Our Lady of Mental Peace

Mother of tranquillity, Mother of Hope, Our Lady of Mental Peace. We reach out to you for what is needful in our weakness. Teach a searching heart that God's love is unchanging, that human love begins and grows by touching God's love.

Let your gentle peace – which the world cannot give – be always with me. And help me to bring this same peace into the lives of others.

Our Lady of Mental Peace – pray for me.

Sympathy

We offer our sympathy to the family and friends of:

Bobby Moran

Kay Callaghan

May they rest in peace

Anniversaries

Please pray for the repose of the souls of:

Sibeal Sharkey

Kathleen Bierwas

Martin Gillespie

Sean Paul Boyle

Majella Quigley

May they rest in peace

Baptisms

We welcome as members of God's family:

Daire Bennett Cassidy

Harrison Dean Quigley

To book a Baptism contact the Parish Office 02871 262894

St Joseph's Boys' School – Return to school information:

Year 12 and 14 – Monday 24 August 2026

Year 9, Year 10 and Year 11 – Wednesday 26 August 2026

Year 8 and Year 13 – Friday 28 August 2026

All year groups full return – Tuesday 1st September 2026 – **All classes will attend from Tuesday 1st September from 8.40am – 3.00pm**

Collection

Weekly Collection: £5,273

Parish Development: £1,016

Thank you for your generosity

Thank you

Fr Farren acknowledges with thanks the following donations for:

Smile Train: £50, £30, £200

Sightsavers: £50, £30, £10, £200

Mary's Meals: £30

Hungry Children: £5

Trócaire: £200

St Vincent de Paul: £200

Concern: £200

Readers for 22nd/23rd August

6.15pm Amulya George

7.30pm Garth Tucker

9.30am Kay McGinn

11.00am Mickey Kerr

12.30pm Michael Wilson

7.00pm Marian Boyle

Sacrament of Marriage

We congratulate

Fiona Corr & Stephen Matthewson

Lauren Doherty & Caolan Cassidy

who celebrated the Sacrament of Marriage recently in the Cathedral

May God bless you abundantly in love, joy and happiness

Job Opportunity, Derry Diocesan Trust: Administrative & Financial Officer (18 hours per week), Waterside Parish, Parochial House, 32 Chapel Road, Derry. Rate of pay: £12.88 per hr - £13.50 per hr. For application packs please email: recruitment@derrydiocese.org or telephone 028 7126 2302. Completed applications must be returned to Personnel, Bishop's House, St Eugene's Cathedral, Francis Street, Derry, BT48 9AP or via email to recruitment@derrydiocese.org no later than 12 noon Monday 24 August 2026. *Derry Diocesan Trust is an Equal Opportunities Employer. We welcome applications from all men and women and from members of all communities.*

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Twentieth Sunday
in Ordinary Time
16th August 2026*

Priests: Fr Paul Farren, Fr Shaun Doherty

Personal Assistants Wanted: The Churches Trust is recruiting people for flexible part-time work supporting and befriending elderly people living independently at home. No experience required – training and support provided. Full clean driving licence and access to a vehicle is required. For more information, call **02871 311322**.

Accord Derry – Marriage Preparation Workshops 2026 - Accord Derry is pleased to announce upcoming Marriage Preparation Workshops taking place in 2026. These courses are designed to support couples as they prepare for the Sacrament of Marriage. The remaining available dates for 2026 are as follows:

- **September:** 25th–26th 2026
- **November:** 20th–21st 2026

All courses are now available for online booking at: www.accordni.com.

Please note that **Accord Derry will not be facilitating Marriage Preparation Courses during October or December 2026**. Couples are encouraged to book early to secure a place on their preferred date.

St Eugene's Cathedral is monitored by CCTV cameras and by two live streaming cameras. Live streaming can be viewed online at www.churchservices.tv, www.watchmcnmedia or the parish website. The Diocese of Derry Privacy Notice is displayed on the parish website and Cathedral notice board, or you may obtain a copy from the Parish Office.

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Northern Ireland emergency services: PSNI (Police Service of Northern Ireland): 101 Social Services: Gateway Services, Western HSC Trust: 028 7131 4090 (and ask for the Duty Social Worker), Gateway Services, Northern HSC Trust: 028 9442 4459, Regional Emergency Social Work Services: 0800 1979 995. Republic of Ireland emergency services: Garda Síochána Buncrana: 00353 749 320 540 Letterkenny: 00353 749 167 100, TUSLA (ROI) Child and Family Agency: 00353 749 102 23